

or religious faith that is his concern, so much as human relations and how these are formed, vitiated and still, somehow renewed.

The protagonist in *Everything There Is*, Vassanji's stand-in for Abdus Salam, is the aptly-named Nurul Islam—of course, for all the light he sheds on both physics and his personal Islamic faith and practice, he is traduced as a plagiarist and an apostate. In conversation, Vassanji extols the possibilities opened up by compartmentalisation. Nurul can work not just collegially but intimately with Abe Rosenfeld on unification theory while never letting politics—over Palestine, say—interfere; he can pursue his desires, for women, or to sit in a church, without necessarily questioning how it affects his status as a Muslim. Scholars, Nurul jokes during a talk, "will bow to any government that supports their research." This is not cowardice, Nurul might argue, or an abandonment of principles and beliefs, but an acceptance of complexity, of contradiction, of doubt. The "world of physics," he muses, "had no national boundaries. It was one single nation, speaking the same language of observation and reason." It's a point Vassanji reiterated at the IIC. But, as Nurul realises, even such a nation was "not without its malignancies, nothing was perfect".

PARTITION CASTS ITS SHADOW OVER NURUL'S FANTASY OF UNIFICATION, OF A PLACE WHERE PEOPLE CAN CONNECT REGARDLESS OF ARTIFICIAL DIVISIONS

When Nurul says to an academic audience that the "decline" in "Muslim lands" is "due in good measure to the rise of fanaticism", to a "belief that science was inimical to true faith", when he says that "science, in its broadest sense, can lead to a unification of cultures", you intuit that he is setting himself up for catastrophe. The balance that he seems to have achieved, the ability, as F. Scott Fitzgerald once noted, of the first-rate intelligence to hold two opposed ideas in mind at the same time, his belief in the possibility of unity now appears naive. Unsurprisingly, hanging over Nurul's life is the biggest schism of all—the division of united India, the scar still fresh and ugly.

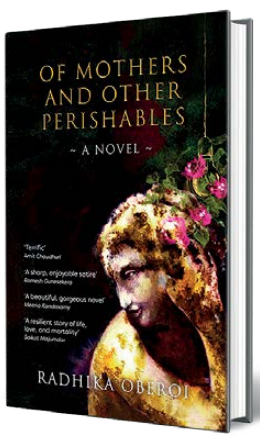
Partition casts its shadow not just over Nurul's love life but also his fantasy of unification, of a place where people can connect regardless of the artificial divisions of politics, religion and culture. It is, some might say, the fantasy of India. "Nowadays," Vassanji said, as he readied his bags for the airport, "fluid identities, syncretism, which was how I was brought up, are no longer accepted. You are either this, or you are that. What does it mean to be this or that? It doesn't make sense to me." Right up to the early 1990s, Vassanji says, maybe even later, there was a looseness to India, a conviction that everything could be absorbed. "That is changing," he says, "and it's changing because of political pressure and divisive rhetoric." Nurul Islam, in that sense, represents subcontinental syncretism, the possibility that individuals are free to eschew borders and imagine their own allegiances, their own faiths. ■

–Shougat Dasgupta

as equal citizens by rolling chapatis for sympathisers. They provide candles to instant converts chanting "Azadi" from the anonymity of their stark lives.

It's a double act that takes place across different timelines. One of them is set in the late 1960s; the other trickles into the near present. Oberoi flies two paper kites against the blandly vacant skyline of the capital, of a mother and daughter whose lives are entangled at the crossroads of its history. The main protagonist is caricatured as The Wailer, courtesy of a Bob Marley anecdote. The Wailer is an emotionally fragile but intellectually brilliant copywriter. She is trapped in a meta world of advertising where brand recognition defines her reality.

There is a second daughter named Toon—think of a Tom and Jerry cartoon. It defines her name and her role as the nemesis to The Wailer. The mother is embalmed between four Godrej cupboards in a dusty storeroom.



OF MOTHERS AND OTHER PERISHABLES
By Radhika Oberoi
SIMON AND SCHUSTER INDIA
₹699; 312 pages

It's an Aladdin's cave of perfumed memories, overflowing with gorgeous zari-etched Banarasi silks and jewellery. To open each one is to be taken on a tour of an upper middle-class life where the baba log expected the enchantment of being heirs to a Nehruvian India of bien pensant socialism to last forever. To reveal more would be to destroy Oberoi's Almodóvar moment. Words survive. If only to light candles in the wind. ■

–Geeta Doctor